Lesson 5 — The Two O'Clock Class

Part 4 of 12: Grammar — the present perfect continuous

Level: A2+ → B1 (fifth step)

About 50 minutes · this part carries a sheet

Come back to: the present simple

Lesson 1 taught the shape and Lesson 2 added where frequency words go. Two lines to remind you:

I / YOU / WE / THEY	WORK
he / she / it	works

New this time: the present simple is not only for habits.

It is also the tense for a timetable or a fixed arrangement:

> The class starts at two o'clock every Saturday.
> The centre opens at nine and closes at four.

And for something that is simply true, with no time attached:

> The electricity comes for about six hours a day.
> Water boils at one hundred degrees.

Look at the first one again. The class starts at two is not a habit at all — it is the timetable, and it can even point at a fixed event in the future (the exam starts on Monday). Arabic would often reach for a future form there. English does not.

Quick practice. Present simple, or present perfect continuous?

1. The class _____ (start) at two o'clock every Saturday.
2. She _____ (teach) the class for eighteen months.
3. The electricity _____ (come) for six hours a day.
4. Her brother _____ (repair) the laptops since the class began.

We use the present perfect continuous for something that started in the past, has gone on for a length of time, and is still going on now: She has been teaching the class for eighteen months — and she is teaching it still.

3.1 How we make it

have / has + been + verb -ing

PERSON	PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS
I / you / we / they	have been working
he / she / it	has been working

3.2 What we use it for

How long something has been going on: He has been repairing those laptops since the class began.

An action that is still happening now: She has been keeping a list since the first Saturday.

Something repeated again and again over a period: They have been learning the same small things.

It almost always comes with for or since, or a phrase like all year, again and again, for the last eighteen months.

3.4 Present perfect, or present perfect continuous?

PRESENT PERFECT — THE RESULT, HOW MANY	PRESENT PERFECT CONTINUOUS — THE ACTIVITY, HOW LONG
He has installed the program four times.	He has been repairing the laptops for a year.
She has not shown the list to anyone.	She has been keeping the list since the first Saturday.
The class has lost four children.	She has been doing this for eighteen months.

A short way to hold it: the simple one counts how many, the continuous one measures how long.

3.5 Negative and question

	FORM	EXAMPLE
Negative	have not / has not been + -ing	She has not been teaching this year.
Question	Have / Has + person + been + -ing	How long has she been teaching?

3.6 Grammar practice

A. Put the verb in the present perfect continuous:

1. Rana _____ (teach) the class for eighteen months.
2. The children _____ (learn) the same small things.
3. Her brother _____ (repair) the laptops since the class began.
4. One girl _____ (teach) her own mother in the evenings.
5. _____ how long _____ you _____ (study) English?

B. Simple or continuous?

1. He (has installed / has been installing) the program four times.
2. She (has kept / has been keeping) the list since the first Saturday.
3. The class (has lost / has been losing) four children.
4. They (have learned / have been learning) the same things again and again.

C. Write for or since:

1. ____ eighteen months
2. ____ the class began
3. ____ the first Saturday
4. ____ three years